



RKDF UNIVERSITY, BHOPAL

Bachelor of Arts (B.A.)

Course	Category	Subject	Subject Code
B.A.	Minor	B.A. Minor Popular Literature (ODL)	BA-EN302
Total Credit: 6		Max.Marks:100 (Internal:40+External:60)	

I Lewis Carroll: *Through the looking Glass*

Keywords: *Youth, Identify Growing up 1820*

II Agantha Christie: *The Murder of Rose Ackroyd*

Keywords: Doubt, Crime, Guilt 1820

III Shyam Selvadurai: *Funny Boy*

Ruskin Bond: *The Room on the Roof*

Keywords: Gender, Marriage, Identity, Children Fiction, Racism etc. . 1820

IV Durgabai Vyam and Subhash Vyam Bhimayama:

Experiences of Untouchability /Autobiographical Notes on **Ambedkar** (*For the Visually Challenged Students*) 1820

V Romantic Fiction Mysterious Stories Fantastic fiction Science fiction and Fantasy

UNIT I

The story of 'Through the Looking-Glass' describes Alice's adventures as she moves symbolically from child to adult in a strange world entered through a mirror above her drawing-room fireplace. The landscape there is in the form of a giant chess board and Alice enters the game as a white pawn. Alice's second adventure takes her through the looking-glass to a place even curiouser than Wonderland. She finds herself caught up in the great looking-glass chess game and sets off to become a queen. It isn't as easy as she expects: at every step she is hindered by nonsense characters who crop up and insist on reciting poems. Some of these poems, such as 'The Walrus and The Carpenter' and 'Jabberwocky', are as famous as the Alice stories themselves. Macmillan was the original publisher of Alice in 1865 and is proud to remain true to the vision of its creators. Every bit as iconic are Sir John Tenniel's remarkable black line illustrations, perfectly capturing the combination of the ordinary and the extraordinary at the heart of Wonderland.

This beautiful, celebratory, edition of Through the Looking-Glass has a gorgeous cover with a shiny silver foiled looking-glass, and is packed full of fun bonus material, including a quiz, word search and a glossary. Lewis Carroll's classic children's book is brought to life like never before! It is the sequel to the immensely popular *Alice's Adventures in Wonderland* (Macmillan, 1866). This second book sold extremely well, with 15,000 copies being bought in the first seven weeks following publication. Most children's books of this time were instructional or were dry tales with a pious moral message so it is not surprising that the satirical and witty *Alice* books flourished, being enjoyed by adults as well as children. Lewis Carroll was the pseudonym of the Reverend Charles Lutwidge Dodgson (1832-1898), a shy mathematics don at Christ Church,

Oxford. He was extremely fond of children and loved to entertain them with puzzles, games and stories he had devised.

The *Alice* books were based on stories he told to entertain the three eldest daughters of the Reverend Henry George Liddell, Dean of Christ Church. Many of the characters in the book would be instantly recognizable to them as they were based on people they knew, in and around Oxford. Dodgson's favorite of the daughters was Alice and it was she who became the heroine of the stories. The story of *Through the Looking-Glass* describes Alice's adventures as she moves symbolically from child to adult in a strange world entered through a mirror above her drawing-room fireplace. The landscape there is in the form of a giant chess board and Alice enters the game as a white pawn. She travels across the board until she is crowned queen at the eighth square. Along the way she encounters some of Carroll's most memorable and enduring characters, among them Tweedledum and Tweedledee, the Walrus and the Carpenter, The Lion and the Unicorn, and the Jabberwock. The book is also filled with many fine nonsense poems and songs which are still quoted from today.

As with *Alice's Adventures in Wonderland* the story ends with Alice waking from a dream but the tone of the book is altogether more melancholy and is prefaced by an extremely sad poem which reflects Dodgson's own feelings about his young child-friends growing up and entering the adult world. By the time *Looking Glass* was published, Alice Liddell was nineteen years old and Dodgson rarely saw her, although he remembered her fondly for the rest of his life. He did, however, send three advance copies of the book to the Liddell family with "the one for Alice being bound in morocco" as he noted in his diary. Our first edition of the book is an octavo volume in red cloth and gilt stamped, with fifty illustrations by Sir John Tenniel (1820-1914), the famous *Punch* artist. Carroll had first thought of writing a sequel to *Alice* as early as 1866 and

approached Tenniel to illustrate, but Tenniel said he was too busy. It took a further two and a half years before Carroll could persuade him to take on the task. The relationship between author and artist had been volatile when Tenniel had illustrated *Wonderland* and was none the less so on this book as both men were perfectionists. This resulted in many changes, including the "Wasp in a Wig" chapter being dropped from the book after Tenniel said it was "beyond the appliances of art." The text of this, intended to appear at the end of chapter eight, was lost for many years but was found and eventually published by Macmillan in 1977. Tenniel's original frontispiece illustration of the Jabberwock was moved further into the text after Carroll deemed it too frightening for his younger readers and was replaced by the image of the white knight.

All the wood engravings for Tenniel's illustrations were made by George and Edward Dalziel who were the leading commercial wood engravers of the Victorian age; they worked with the most famous artists and illustrators of the period, such as Cruikshank, Millais and Burne-Jones. The original woodblocks for the *Alice* books were discovered in a vault of the National Westminster Bank in Covent Garden in 1985 and are now on permanent loan to the British Library. Most woodblocks of this period were broken up or re-used but these survived thanks to Carroll's concern for their safekeeping, probably due the large sum of money he had to pay for them. His contract with publisher Macmillan, which was by no means unusual for the time, meant that he had to bear all the costs of publishing the book, and even of advertising it. Macmillan simply sold it on commission. The association between author and publisher was a fruitful and enduring one which lasted some thirty-five years, until the author's death.

The last edition of *Through the Looking-Glass* to be published in the author's lifetime appeared in 1879 and included his final alterations. As well as the *Alice* books, Dodgson also published some mathematical treatises and nonsense poems and parodies. His other fictional works

include *Phantasmagoria and other poems* (1869), *The Hunting of the Snark* (1876), and *Sylvie and Bruno* (1889) but none have captured the public imagination so much as the *Alice* books which remain popular and influential over 130 years after they were first written.

UNIT II

Agatha Christie: *The Murder of Rose Ackroyd*

Summary: Chapter 1: Dr. Sheppard at the Breakfast Table

On the morning of September 17, Dr. James Sheppard arrives home in a state of agitation from an early morning emergency police call to King's Paddock, the home of Mrs. Ferrars, where he was summoned to give the time and manner of her death. He puts the time of death in the overnight hours of September 16–17 and the cause as an overdose of vernal, a barbiturate sleep aid. Dr. Sheppard's sister, Caroline, with whom he lives, has already gotten the news of the death from the milkman, who heard the news from Mrs. Ferrars's cook and parlormaid, Annie. Caroline theorizes that Mrs. Ferrars committed suicide out of remorse for having poisoned her husband Ashley Ferrars a year prior. Dr. Sheppard tries to discourage his sister's speculations while secretly sharing her suspicions.

Summary: Chapter 2: Who's who in King's Abbot?

Dr. Sheppard introduces his fellow residents of the town of King's Abbot. Its most prominent citizen, the wealthy widower Roger Ackroyd, lives at the house named Fernly Park with his late brother Cecil's widow, Mrs. Ackroyd, and her daughter, Flora Ackroyd. Twenty-five years prior, Roger had married a widow by the name of Paton, who had a son, Ralph Paton. Roger's wife died of alcoholism four years later, leaving Roger to raise Ralph, who is now twenty-five years old.

The Ferrars had only lived in the King's Paddock house a few months when Ashley Ferrars, a notorious drunkard, died. Caroline asserts that Mrs. Ferrars poisoned him, but Dr. Sheppard reminds her that he ruled the cause of death as acute gastritis while privately reflecting that

Ashley's symptoms *were* similar to arsenic poisoning. Roger Ackroyd and Mrs. Ferrars developed a relationship that the town expected was heading toward marriage despite Roger's housekeeper, Miss Russell, having made herself indispensable for the past five years.

Dr. Sheppard ponders the official ruling he must make on Mrs. Ferrars's cause of death—suicide or murder. He last recollects seeing her in an intense conversation with Ralph Paton. Roger tells Dr. Sheppard he has an urgent need to speak with him, but it's not about Ralph, whom he believes is in London. A local busybody, Miss Gannett, claims to have proof that Roger and Mrs. Ferrars were engaged. Miss Russell visits Dr. Sheppard's office and asks him questions about cures for a cocaine habit as well as poisons that are in detectable.

Summary: Chapter 3: The Man Who Grew Vegetable Marrows

At lunchtime on September 17, Caroline tells Dr. Sheppard that Ralph Paton arrived in King's Abbot the morning of September 16 and is staying at the Three Boars inn rather than at Fernly Park with his stepfather, Roger. Dr. Sheppard meets their next-door neighbor, a Mr. Porrott, who apologizes for throwing a marrow squash over the fence in a fit of frustration. In the course of their conversation, Mr. Porrott reveals a friendship with Roger Ackroyd dating back to Mr. Porrott's former work; a profession that he prefers remains unknown. Mr. Porrott passes on Roger's news that Ralph and Flora Ackroyd are engaged.

Later, Caroline arrives home from town, where she had run into Roger and told him Ralph was staying at the Three Boars. She also recounts having overheard Ralph and a woman discussing Ralph's inheritance and Ralph expressing concern that his stepfather, Roger, is considering cutting him out of his will. Dr. Sheppard goes to the Three Boars to visit Ralph, who confides that he's in a dilemma that no one but he can resolve.

Analysis: Chapters 1–3

The conversation between Dr. Sheppard and Caroline in Chapter 1 introduces a central theme of the novel: the value of raw information and the ability to interpret it correctly. Caroline understands how valuable—and powerful—information can be. She makes it her business to collect and spread information in King’s Abbot, and though this proclivity annoys Dr. Sheppard to no end he nonetheless marvels at her ability. When Caroline states her theory about the demise of Mr. and Mrs. Ferrars, Dr. Sheppard calls it “nonsense.” Privately he reveals that he is inclined to believe Caroline’s theory but disapproves of *how* she has arrived at it, calling it “inspired guesswork.” Dr. Sheppard’s narration here implies a distinction between information and truth: these are not the same, and to find the truth, a person must gather information and correctly interpret it.

Dr. Sheppard jokes that the main recreational activity in King’s Abbot can be summed up as “gossip,” and despite his professed distaste for it, he nevertheless goes on to describe the “halo of gossip” surrounding King Abbot’s most important resident, Roger Ackroyd. The novel’s title foreshadows that Ackroyd will be murdered, which casts an ominous light on the gossip surrounding Ackroyd’s family and acquaintances. The talk of poisons, secret conversations, and the implication that there are any number of people who might be glad to see the last of Roger Ackroyd is not subtle. The information comes thick and fast in these early chapters, creating an increasing need for interpretation. It’s a dizzying narrative, highlighted by Dr. Sheppard and Caroline’s discussion of the latest gossip in Chapter 3. It is therefore the perfect time to be introduced to the man whose business it is to gather information and find the truth through interpretation, Mr. Hercule Poirot. Very little is known about Mr. Poirot, exemplified by the villagers even getting his name wrong (“Mr. Porrot”). But Mr. Poirot is happy to “remain

incognito,” hinting that he is the type of person who, like Caroline, understands the value and power of information. At the same time, Mr. Poirot is curious about the local gossip, and it is perhaps no coincidence that he has decided to live next door to the town’s most prolific purveyor of information about the goings on in King’s Abbot. This theme of the power of information surfaces throughout the novel as Poirot attempts to root out deliberate misinformation (lies) as well as the deliberate withholding of key pieces of information by various suspects. nancy to the intrigue.

Dr. James Sheppard, the story's narrator, lives with his unmarried sister Caroline in the English country village of King’s Abbot. Telling the story in his own words, Dr. Sheppard recounts being called to certify the death of a wealthy widow, Mrs. Ferrars, who has committed suicide a year after her abusive husband's demise. Caroline speculates that Mrs. Ferrars had poisoned her husband and has committed suicide out of remorse.

Roger Ackroyd, wealthy widower and owner of Fernly Park, tells Dr. Sheppard that he needs to talk to him urgently, and invites him to dinner that evening. In addition to Dr. Sheppard, the dinner guests include Major Blunt, Ackroyd's sister-in-law Mrs. Cecil Ackroyd, her daughter Flora, and Ackroyd's personal secretary Geoffrey Raymond. Flora tells the doctor that she is engaged to be married to Ralph Paton, Ackroyd's stepson, though the engagement is being kept confidential.

In his study after dinner, Ackroyd tells Dr. Sheppard that he had been engaged to Mrs. Ferrars for several months, and that she admitted yesterday that she had indeed poisoned her husband. She was being blackmailed, and promised to reveal the blackmailer's name within 24 hours. At

this point Ackroyd's butler, Parker, enters with a letter that Mrs. Ferrars had posted just before she killed herself. Ackroyd apologetically asks Dr. Sheppard to leave so that he can read it alone.

Shortly after arriving back home, the doctor receives a phone call and, stopping just long enough to shout to Caroline that the caller is Parker reporting that Ackroyd has been found dead, he rushes straight back to Fernly Park. On his arrival, Parker professes to know nothing about the phone call. Unable to get a response at the study door, Sheppard and Parker break it down and find Ackroyd dead in his chair, killed with his own dagger. The letter is missing, and footprints are found leading in and out of the study through an open window.

Ralph disappears, and becomes the primary suspect when the footprints are found to match shoes that he owns. Flora, convinced that Ralph is innocent, asks the recently-retired detective Hercule Poirot if he will investigate.

Asking Dr. Sheppard to accompany him, Poirot visits the scene of the crime. Parker notices that a chair has been moved. Poirot questions the guests and staff including Ursula Bourne, the parlormaid, who has no alibi. The window of opportunity for the murderer after Dr. Sheppard's departure appears to have been quite short as Raymond and Blunt later heard Ackroyd talking in his study, and Flora says she saw him just before going up to bed. Poirot unravels a complex web of intrigue, and presents the missing Ralph Paton – who was, it transpires, already secretly married to Ursula when Ackroyd had decided that he should marry Flora. The pair had arranged a clandestine meeting in the garden. Flora is forced to admit she never in fact saw her uncle after dinner, leaving Raymond and Blunt as the last people to hear Ackroyd alive. Blunt confesses his love for Flora.

Alone with Dr. Sheppard, Poirot reveals he knows that Dr. Sheppard himself is the blackmailer and Ackroyd's killer. Realizing that Mrs. Ferrars's letter would implicate him, Sheppard had

stabbed Ackroyd before leaving the study. He left publicly through the front door, then put Ralph's shoes on, ran round to the study window and climbed back in. Locking the door from the inside, he set a desk dictaphone going, playing a recording of Ackroyd's voice, and pulled out a chair to hide it from anyone standing in the doorway. To provide the excuse for returning to Fernly Park, he had asked a patient to call him at home. While Sheppard had the study to himself for a few minutes after the crime was discovered, he slipped the dictaphone into his medical bag, and replaced the chair.

Poirot tells Sheppard that this will be reported to the police in the morning, and he suggests that to spare his sister Caroline the doctor might take his own life. Dr. Sheppard finishes writing his report on Poirot's investigation (the novel itself), with his last chapter – *Apologia* – serving as his suicide note.

UNIT III

Funny Boy Summary

Funny Boy is a story about a seven-year-old boy Arjun (Arjie) who goes on to experience not only the ups and downs that accompany the discovery of one's sexuality, but also the harsh reality of the real world. Told from the point of view of Arjie, *Funny Boy* is not just about the taboo topic of homosexuality in a close-minded society, but also a story that tells how political and regional conflicts affect people's lives. Though Arjie's homosexuality and how he understands it and deals with it are some of the important themes in the story, the political conflict between the Tamils and Sinhalese people in Sri Lanka where Arjie resides with his family also plays a very important role in shaping the story. It tells the readers about the sufferings of people from both sides since Arjie is from a mixed Tamil/Sinhalese family and since the narrator is Arjie himself, we get a personal view of these conflicts affecting innocent people caught in the crossfire.

Divided into six chapters, the first few parts capture Arjie's childhood and recall the various episodes that introduce the whole family and the protagonist Arjie himself. The later chapters start to focus on the political tension brewing up in the nation and Arjie's discovery of his own sexuality.

The first story, "Pigs Can't Fly," takes place during the "spend the days." The grandchildren of the family are playing a favorite game of theirs called Bride-Bride where Arjie is always the bride and the girls love it when because he plays the part so well and see nothing wrong with it. However, the peace is soon disrupted when Arjie and all his female cousins are playing, but Tanuja, nicknamed Her Fatness, refuses to let Arjie be the bride. The rest of the girls take Arjie's side and shoo away Tanuja which leads to Tanuja's mother, Aunty Kanthy, to come to see what

the matter is. She sees Arjie dressed up in a saree and cruelly drags him to the living room where everyone is gathered. Seeing Arjie, a boy, dressed up in saree and playing a game meant for girls, his parents are embarrassed. An uncle calls Arjie “a funny one.” His mother explains that he cannot play with the girls anymore because “the sky is so high and pigs can’t fly, that’s why.” In “Radha Aunty,” Radha Aunty has returned from America. Though she is not all what Arjie had imagined her to be, she and Arjie quickly become close, and are involved in a performance of *The King and I*. Rajan Nagendra, an acquaintance of Radha Aunty proposes to Radha, but she is reluctant to accept. She becomes friends with Anil Jayasinghe, a Sinhalese who is also involved in the play. The family tells Radha to end her friendship with Anil, and Radha leaves for Jaffna to forget about Anil. On the train back home, she and several other Tamils are attacked by Sinhalese violent crowds, and soon after, Radha is engaged to Rajan. These events lead Arjie’s father to explain to Arjie about the Tamil-Sinhalese conflict and Arjie comes to realize how serious the matter is.

In “See No Evil, Hear No Evil,” Uncle Daryl returns to Sri Lanka from Australia. Arjie’s father is in Europe on a business trip at this time. Daryl aims to investigate assertions of government torture. Arjie slowly becomes aware that there is something going on between his mother and Uncle Daryl. Arjie gets sick, and Amma takes him to the country where Uncle Daryl visits them. Daryl also goes to Jaffna, where there are violent events taking place. Arjie’s mother requests Daryl not to interfere, but Daryl continues on his way and goes missing. Daryl’s body is found on the beach. They are told that he drowned, but Arjie and his mother suspect that he was murdered first. Arjie’s mother tries to dig deeper about the death of Uncle Daryl, but the lawyer states that there is nothing she can do. He references the three wise monkeys and suggests that she behaves similarly.

Arjie's father's friend Jegan begins to work with him at his hotel in the chapter "Small Choices." Jegan was known to associate with the Tamil Tigers, but claims that he broke all connections long ago. Jegan also befriends Arjie, who starts to notice his homosexuality for the first time. The political tensions in the country continues to build, and Jegan is accused of plotting to assassinate a Tamil politician. His room at the hotel is vandalized, and Arjie's father fires Jegan, who may go back to his violent past after all though it is not told with certainty.

In the next-to-last chapter, "The Best School of All," Arjie's father becomes suspicious about Arjie's sexuality and mannerism and decides that Arjie will be transferred to the Victoria Academy. He says the school will school Arjie into becoming a man. There, Arjie meets Shehan and also the school principal. Arjie is warned by his own brother about Shehan's sexuality, claiming that Shehan is gay and to stay away from him. But Arjie and Shehan continue to spend more time together, and Arjie becomes more and more attracted to his friend. The school principal, Black Tie, asks Arjie to recite several poems at an upcoming school event. Black Tie says that these poems are important because they will plead with the government not to reorganize the school. Arjie is nervous, and fails to recall all the lines of the poem. The principal punishes Arjie for not being able to recite poems perfectly and also beats Shehan for not helping Arjie memorize his lines. However, Arjie realizes that this punishment was meted out to a certain crowd of students, those like Shehan and Arjie, the not so "manly" ones. One day, Shehan kisses Arjie, who begins to understand and acknowledge his own sexuality. Soon after they have their first sexual encounter in Arjie's parents' garage. Later, Arjie is deeply ashamed and disgusted by himself, and believes he has failed his family and betrayed their trust. Still later, Arjie purposefully messes up his poem recital again after Shehan breaks down because of Black Tie's frequent beatings.

In the final story in Selvadurai's *Funny Boy*, "Riot Journal: An Epilogue," the tensions between the two sides, the Tamils and the Sinhalese, in Sri Lanka has come to a head. Rioters ravage the area, burning down the Tamil houses and businesses throughout the town of Colombo. The family runs for safety, and hides in a neighbor's house. They go into hiding after an angry mob comes to burn down their home. Soon after that, their hotel is burned down, and Ammachi and Appachi, Arjie's grandparents, are killed. This is finally the moment when the family decides to leave the country. Arjie and Shehan make love for one last time, before he is forced to say goodbye, never to see his friend and lover again. Then Arjie and his family leave their country, their homeland Sri Lanka, and move to Canada.

Summary of the Room On the Roof By Ruskin Bond

The Story of "Room on the Roof" follows a boy named Rusty, a 17 years old boy with no parents who live in Dehradun, Uttarakhand with his English guardians. Ruskin don't want to live with his English guardian anymore because of their strictness towards him. The "Room on the roof" is a first novel of famous Indian author Ruskin Bond and he wrote it when he was just 17 years old. The novel was originally published in 1956 and it has won John Llewellyn Rhys Prize in 1957. The story of novel center around Rusty, 17 years old Anglo Indian orphaned boy who lives with his guardian named Mr. John Harrison and Mrs. Harrison. The Second important character of novel is Mr. John Harrison, very strict English man who don't like Indian at all and want Rusty to stay away from Indian because he want him to be a complete Englishman. The third important character of novel is Kishan, a neighbor of Rusty who learned daily English from him. The Story of novel starts

with Rusty, a 17 years old boy with no parents who lives in Dehradun, Uttarakhand with his guardian named Mr John Harrison. His guardians are very strict who don't like Indian at all and they does not allow Rusty to live or play with Indian because they want him to be a complete English man. Rusty do not like living with his guardian because of their strict behavior towards him for Indian and he longs for liberation. One day in morning during light rain when Rusty was returning home he meets a boy named Somi and Ranbir who helps him by giving him lift through bicycle and they go on to become Rusty's best friends.

When Mr. and Mrs. Harrison were not in home Rusty decides to go in market with his best friends Somi and Ranbir and after enjoying with his best friends when Rusty return back to home he find out that his guardian has come back early and he gets punishment for going in market. The next day he goes to play Holy with his best friends Somi and Ranbir and one more time when he came back he get punishment for playing with his friends but this time Rusty gets angry and in anger he starts fighting with Mr. John Harrison, and when Mr. Harrison wife comes he runs away from their home.

Rusty spend first time in his life whole night outside the home crying and waiting for his best friend Somi who will come in morning to take him in his home because he don't want to go back at his guardian home. In morning Somi comes and takes him in his home and help Rusty in getting a job as English teacher in Mr. and Mrs. Kapoor home.

Mr. and Mrs. Meena Kapoor hired him as English teacher for their son named Kishan and they gave him room on the roof in their home to live freely. Mr. Kapoor is a alcoholic man who is 20 years older than his wife, Meena and don't care for her at all. Rusty starts attracting towards Mrs. Kapoor because of her beauty and on the other hand Mrs. Meena Kapoor also seems attracted towards him as she feel uncared by her spouse. One day Mr. and Mrs. Meena Kapoor go to Delhi for their personal work and after few days Rusty gets horrific news that Mr. & Mrs. Meena Kapoor had an car accident in which Mrs. Meena died.

Kishan and Rusty were shocked after hearing the news of Meena's death and they feel very sad and heartbroken for their lost. Mrs. Meena Kapoor's death make Rusty orphaned again and now he live alone in his room on the roof. Rusty decides to go England by taking help from British Embassy and before going England he goes to meet his friend Kishan who is living in Haridwar with his aunt. When he went to Haridwar to meet Kishan he learns that Mr. Kapoor has married another woman and Kishan don't live with them anymore. When Rusty meet Kishan he learns that he has chosen a life of crime and became a thief. Rusty advises him to quit a life of crime and thief because he don't want to see him in prison, he told him to start a new life in Dehradun. The next morning Rusty and Kishan leaves for Dehradun to start a new life together.

UNIT 4

Durgabai Vyam and Subhash Vyam Bhimayama:

Experiences of Untouchability /Autobiographical Notes on **Ambedkar** (*For the Visually Challenged Students*) 1820

Through the themes and incidents, Bhimayana links two crucial issues -Caste and the everyday experience of both Ambedkar in the past and Dalits in the present. The three themes Bhimayana is built around are water, shelter and travel project, and how Caste becomes an inseparable unit of everyday experience. The images and text in the book Bhimayana tell the story of Ambedkar, an untouchable and a revolutionist. The book takes us through the problems he faced in childhood and still in adulthood, after he graduated from Columbia University and having Sayaji Rao (raja of Baroda State) sponsors his education. Bhimrao Ramji Ambedkar (1891–1956), one of India’s foremost revolutionaries, grew up untouchable. Battling against the odds, he gained multiple doctorates, campaigned against social discrimination and the caste system and went on to draft the Constitution of India.

Throughout his life Ambedkar faced routine discrimination: in school at the age of 10; in Baroda after his return from Columbia University; and while travelling in later life. The discrimination experienced by Ambedkar continues to haunt a majority of India’s 170 million Dalits as many are still denied water, shelter and the basic dignities of life. The book is dedicated to Jangarh Singh Shyam, a pioneer in contemporary Pardhan Gond art. He is credited by Udayan Vajpeyi to be the creator of a new school of art called Jangarh Kalam.^[4] He encouraged and guided Durgabai and Subhash Vyam, along with many other members of the Pardhan Gond community, to become artists. He was also Subhash Vyam's brother-in-law.

In the foreword, art critic John Berger, most famous for his 1972 essay “Ways of Seeing”, commends the refreshing form of story-telling that the book uses. Of it, he says, ‘No more

proscenium arch. No more rectangular framing or unilinear time. No more profiled individuals. Instead, a conference of corporeal experiences across generations, full of pain and empathy, and nurtured by a complicity and endurance that can outlive the Market'. He believes that such texts will make readers more vested in the story and its message. The graphic account begins with a frame story of an unnamed character complaining about 'these damn job quotas for Backward and Scheduled Castes!' who is immediately challenged by another character leading to a conversation about the history of caste atrocities in India. He is advised to read about Ambedkar to understand what happened at Khairlanji.

The book then moves on to the narrative of Ambedkar's life in Books I, II and III. Debates on the caste system and Dr. Ambedkar as a powerful Dalit Intellectual are burgeoning in various political and literary discourses. This paper aims to provide critical insight into the Graphic biography, *Bhimayana: Experiences of Untouchability*, published in 2011. This seems a political document to problematize the concerns of the caste experience of Dalits in India. Dr. Ambedkar is a highly educated urban youth. Although he contributed immensely to divergent areas of India, his anti-caste struggles are the most important among them. This work is a unique piece of biography, which provides some information about the experience of Ambedkar, which other conventional biographies did not take up. There are various opinions regarding the literary genre of *Bhimayana*. Nandini Chandra, in her review, observes that "while the publishers shy away from calling it a graphic novel, and stick to the universal category 'graphic book', the overarching frame in which it is slotted, marked, and reviewed is that of the graphic novel" (1). Nayar, on the other hand, observes that "the graphic novel as a medium is apposite for capturing the horrors of political oppression and the decay of democracy" (Postcolonial 131). Graphic literary pieces are often considered to be long comic narratives for a mature audience, with severe literary themes

and sophisticated artwork. However, Graphic Biography is another term that can be used to place the text generally. It also helps readers to comprehend concept easily through images. Directly, the book shows a textual–visual narrative of the Untouchability experienced by Ambedkar in his personal life. However, the “central character is not Ambedkar alone but also the degrading grind of Dalit life among the 60 million in Ambedkar’s time” (Desai n. Pag.). This book reconnoitres social and political voices intersect with the visual signification, and it gives an overall impression that it has an objective to teach people, including non-Dalit, who often ignore the outstanding contribution of Ambedkar to India. Socio-religious engagements in India backed the liberation of the Dalits from the yoke of oppressive forces

Bhimrao Ambedkar was an ever-green icon who craved to get justice and equality. “Dr B.R Ambedkar also strongly stood for the eradication of exploitation and the equal status in the society” (MK 2). He was an object of harsh criticism and political carelessness, notwithstanding his lifelong endeavor to reform the social condition of Indian society caught by the rigid caste system. This work explores the general public's ignorance about Ambedkar and his anti-caste struggle. The agony and suffering represented by Dalit writers and critics are not only talking about an individual but the marginalized section of society. The word 'Dalit' derives from a Sanskrit word, which means 'suppressed' or 'crushed. On the other hand, the Oxford dictionary defines 'Dalit; as a member of the Caste that is considered the lowest and has the fewest advantages. They were restricted to access to prestigious jobs; as a result, they had to cope with menial occupations like leather work, butchering, and lower-grade work. Moreover, they were also to use public wells, schools and rivers. It is reported on many historical occasions about the restrictions of Dalits from entering temples. However, socio- religious renaissance movements in India advocated for the liberation of the Dalits from oppressive forces. DR B.R Ambedkar also

firmly stood for eradicating exploitation and equal societal status. In Dalit literature, a Dalit expresses his anger and resentment of Dalits against social inequality. Limbale, a famous Dalit literary critic and writer, observes that:

To start with, there will have to be a definite explanation of the word 'Dalit' in Dalit Literature. Harijans and neo-Buddhists are not the only Dalits, the term describes all the untouchable communities living outside the boundary of the village, as well as Adivasis, landless farm labours, workers, the suffering masses, and nomadic and criminal tribes. In explaining the word, it will not do to refer only to the untouchable castes. People who are lagging behind economically will also need to be included (30)

Dalit works have created their unique aesthetics among the mainstream Indian Writing in English literature. All of these critique the social snobbery and preoccupied reservation on the downtrodden sections of society. Dalit literature often touches upon caste oppression, the question of identity, poverty, Untouchability and inevitable revolution. Dalit literature also questions canonical literature, which they call; Hindu literature. Dalit literature ultimately aims to uproot caste oppression by denying the Varna order of Hindu belief. Dalit literature often draws attention to the sorrows, tribulations, slavery, humiliation, poverty, etc., experienced by Dalits.

Dalit literature is not mere fiction. It is part of the more significant move to bring about changes. Dalit writings are based on real-life incidents. Some critics believe that people like Prem Chand and Mulk Raj Anand project the Dalit life as it is; instead, they represent Dalits as hapless and mischievous who cannot take their own decisions and action. One such example is Bakha in *Untouchable*, who concedes to Gandhi's pacifism rather than going for revolution. Post-

independent events and fundamental transformation changed the life of people. The democratic form of government and different welfare schemes helped ordinary people understand the country's rights and laws. However, over time, new movements in post-independence emerged against rampant corruption, poverty, and unemployment, atrocities against ethnic and religious minorities. Unfortunately, the spirit of education spread among people has not helped society to change the narrow-mindedness towards weaker sections of society. Widespread discourse on resistance literature intensified a sort of consciousness of liberation in Dalit's quest for dignity and social justice.

Dalit authors and activists refuse to abide by the established tradition as they think they do not belong. At the same time, they firmly hold that the tradition of Budha, Phule, Kabeer and Ambedkar was an inevitable part of their tradition. It showed resistant tradition against established tradition and the hegemonic nature of the established tradition. Dr. B.R Ambedkar fought against the segregated attitudes of upper-class Hindus both in India and abroad. Dr. BR Ambedkar's thoughts helped Dalits comprehend their distress and fundamental human rights. The Politics of collectiveness is visible in most Dalit writings. It is a collective social voice for equality, liberty, fraternity, and justice. Their consciousness to free Dalits from the intensified bitter experience and expression of their anguish is a kind of revolt. Another important political aspect of Dalit writings is their language and narrative style. They reject the upper-class language; they always lash out at the so-called standard language, validated by upper-class people, because they think this is a language of oppression and subjugation.

Moreover, the standard language lacks many unique cultural vocabularies of Dalit lives. Dalit writers do not bank upon Hindu sacred literature's existing symbols and metaphors. Instead, they

construct new myths; using the Hindu scripture's symbol would be a deconstructed myth or symbol with a new meaning. Dr. Ambedkar's view on literature is also important to be highlighted. He asserts that writers should take inspiration from the experience of ordinary people. "Transform the light of your pen so that the darkness of the village is removed. Do not forget that in our country, the world of the Dalits and the ignored classes is extremely large. Get to know their pain and sorrow intimately, and try through your literature to bring progress in their lives" (qtd in Limabale 50).

All illustrations of *Bhimayana* follow the style of the traditional Gond Paintings, with two-dimensional flat figures defying everyday anatomical perspectives. It encompasses digna patterns and nature imagery. A strong passion for the environment is generated in art by incorporating flora and fauna. The Gonda folklore is a platform where "Imagination and tradition combine to create a world where gods, bird, animals and man live in harmony" (Prakashn. Pag.). *Bhimayana* succeeds by contributing to the visual literacy and graphic genre and takes the task of recasting the subjugation of the marginalized.

Bhimayana established a new method for modern writers, artists and academicians to follow. This book highlights many acts of denial of fundamental rights by including snapshots of original newspaper reports. The text attempt to foreground these situations. The shifting of the narrative discourse between past and present imparts a certain amount of contemporariness to the text. The events in the life of Ambedkar, the use of two travels from the present-day generation, and the conversational mode in which the discussion on Ambedkar's life is initiated give a unique quality to the book, which is rarely traced in other biographies of Ambedkar. The woman

character in *Bhimayana* could be seen as a politically conscious choice. The young educated woman traveller impedes seeing the dominant caste predispositions in the social sphere. She teaches the man who tries to confront the problem of unemployment. The first glance, the book gives an impression that it is a children's book with coloured pictures. However, by the course of reading, readers can realize that it is a serious deliberation on important burning issues in India. The leading characters are waiting for a bus; the discourse occurs between a young woman and a male traveller. The man is in search of a job. He complains about Caste-based reservations in India as he thinks that prevents him from getting a job. The woman narrates to him about the bitter experience and struggle of Ambedkar, who was born and brought up in a Dalit family.

The gentleman disagreed with the lady at the end of the conversation; still, he wishes to know more about him and his actions. The process of adopting a graphic narrative model to deliver serious problems in society is innovative and adorable. *Bhimayana* employs this technique to articulate caste atrocities and oppressions. Nayar argues that “*Bhimayana* makes caste-based oppression and its history visible by steering clear of standard modes of documenting oppression and shifting it into the demotic, or populist, register, even within/among the elite readership for Indian writing in English” (The Indian 141). The non-Dalit traveller in the *Bhimayana* made an anti-reservation comment at the novel’s beginning. “Super qualified. Stuck in a dead-end job. That is my life...I blame these damn job quotas on backward and scheduled Castes. It is not fair” (Vyam 11). *Bhimayana* proclaims through the character of a lady traveller that “caste is not fair” and moves on substantiating the claim with the support of solid evidence from news reports of caste atrocities (11). This graphic novel acquires an ideological outlook and popular inducement. It stays impressive in its creative reflection and politically oriented textual depictions.

The section “Travel” in *Bhimayana* deals with the experiences of Ambedkar related to his journey, mainly in India, where he had to encounter the evil of the caste system. The pleasure of a journey as a Dalit is often replaced by the apprehension of being caught by the upper caste. One example was when Ambedkar visited Doulatabad Fort in Aurangabad in 1934; he was “welcomed” by Muslims with abusive words on him though it was the month of Holy Ramzan (Vyam 86). Another example says that child Bhimrao was denied water from the school for being untouchable in 1901. Anand ruminates the creation of *Bhimayana* as a small effort to disclose the offensive and chilling silence regarding caste and to make the story of Ambedkar widely known. (113) Contemporary India continues with caste practices in gross and subtle forms.

Newspaper reports on everyday caste atrocities constitute the space in *Bhimayana*. For example, while a page discusses caste atrocities, the adjacent page displays snapshots of newspaper accounts of caste-based violence. The intricacy of dealing with issues of Caste cannot be neglected. *Bhimayana* portrayed the issue. Also, the notion of every day has become a severe matter of discussion and relevance in contemporary cultural studies. Through the themes and incidents, *Bhimayana* links two crucial issues -Caste and the everyday experience of both Ambedkar in the past and Dalits in the present. The three themes *Bhimayana* is built around are water, shelter and travel project, and how Caste becomes an inseparable unit of everyday experience. *Bhimayana* exposes the graphic dissonance by projecting the unheard self of a national leader, which is rooted in the purely personal experiences of bitterness in the name of Caste. The book's emphasis on the most personal component of an individual represents the incidents and struggles of the lower strata of society.

UNIT V

Romantic fiction

Romance fiction refers to fictional narratives that feature the theme of love and chivalry in a sentimental fashion. Romance fiction is one of the categories of genre fiction, wherein the reader knows what to expect from a narrative based on its genre. Romantic Fiction has two strict criteria: The first is that the story must focus on the relationship and romantic love between two people. Secondly, the end of the story must be positive, leaving the reader believing that the protagonists' love and relationship will endure for the rest of their lives.

The characteristics of romantic fiction are:-

A focus on a romantic relationship. This seems a bit like a duh, but it seems worth mentioning. ...

- A conflict standing in the way. Every novel has to have conflict and novels in the romance genre are no different. ...
- A strong female lead. ...
- A happy ending.

In the world of literature, few genres capture the hearts and imaginations of readers quite like romance novels. From passionate love affairs set in historical eras to modern-day tales of soul mates finding each other in the workplace or other contemporary settings, romance novels have a special place in the hearts of readers. If you aspire to write a romance novel that will captivate readers and leave them yearning for more, it's essential to understand the key elements that make up the genre and contribute to the most successful romance novels ever written. Drawing on over 25 years' experience printing romance novels for both mainstream publishing houses, small presses, and self-publishers, we'll walk you step by step through the 10 essential elements of

romance writing, offering insights and tips on how to craft an unforgettable love story that will keep readers turning the pages. Let's get started!

1. Romance is at the heart of romance!

A romance novel is a work of extended prose fiction that revolves around the theme of love. The growth of a love relationship between two individuals must be the primary subject of a romance novel, according to the RWA (Romance Writers of America). Yes, you can write in all the subgenres of romance from science fiction romance to romantic thrillers to paranormal romance and many more; but to be a true romance novel, that relationship between two people *must* be the central theme and the beating heart of the plot and characters' development. Think of a historical novel and a historical romance, as an example. The historical novel will almost certainly have a romantic subplot, but the core theme of the story will be heroic, or political, or social, or rags-to-riches, or... whatever. The romance is only secondary. In the historical romance, however, the love-story is the *keystone*, and the rest is really just for setting and atmosphere.

The genre is characterized by its emotional through-line and an optimistic conclusion, often referred to as a “happily ever after” or a “happy for now” ending. If you're thinking of breaking the mold by writing a tragic love story; well, you can do that—look at the success of “Love Story”—but it won't sell as a “romance”. The genre absolutely demands a happy ending. If you don't provide it, your readers will never forgive you. While “traditional” romance novels are usually about a heterosexual couple, contemporary romance stories can just as well involve LGBTQIA+ relationships. Indeed, these days, rainbow romance is a burgeoning genre with several imprints dedicated to publishing it.

So, we've highlighted the first essential component of a successful romance novel: romance! So, what makes this romance work and how do you sustain a book-length story about it and turn it into a gripping, page-turning plot? The rest of the points put together will answer that question.

Write rounded characters

One of the key elements of a successful romance novel is relatable and interesting characters. It was E. M. Forster, in his excellent guide to fiction writing, *Aspects of the Novel*, who first defined characters in fiction as being “flat” or “rounded”. It comes down to credibility and depth. Flat characters have only one driving force to them—think of your pulp fiction heroes—and are all good or all bad or plainly indifferent. Rounded characters have multiple levels to their personalities, well thought out back stories and complex motivations. They experience inner struggles and must work through conflict to make tough decisions; they're complex, flawed characters. When you write romance, avoid the stereotypes and work hard to develop fully rounded characters.

As readers immerse themselves in a love story, they want to connect with the characters on a deep emotional level. Most romance readers are straight females, so if you're writing traditional heterosexual romance, it's crucial to create a relatable heroine that readers can sympathize with and root for throughout the story. Avoid creating a one-dimensional character and instead focus on making your heroine human, flawed, and capable of growth. And give her strengths and make her capable. The swooning heroines of old-fashioned romances are long gone. A strong, self-directed lead is a must in today's publishing environment. Of course, she can go weak-kneed in the arms of her lover. But let that be in contrast to her day-to-day capabilities. She needs her own motivations, needs, and desires and you must make sure that she plays a proactive part in getting them fulfilled.

An irresistible hero

In a traditional romance novel, the hero must conform to certain stereotypical characteristics, physical appearance, and personality traits. Yes, there's a little more wriggle room nowadays than a decade ago, but readers still want their heroes handsome, powerful, and courageous. So, your hero must be irresistible, capturing the hearts of both the heroine and the reader. While physical attractiveness is important, it's equally vital to give the hero depth and flaws that make him relatable and authentic. You need to match your hero and heroine well in this way. Just as the traditional "pretty princess" role of the heroine must be subverted by extension to make her more gutsy and independent, so the well-rounded hero should possess qualities such as sensitivity, intelligence, and emotional intelligence along with strength and good looks. By creating a hero and heroine who complement each other and share undeniable chemistry, you will keep readers invested in the love story and eager to see their journey unfold.

Plan a memorable meet-cute

When the hero and heroine—or the two protagonists in a non-heterosexual or non-binary format—meet, often referred to in the industry as the "meet-cute," is a crucial element in any romance novel. This initial encounter should be memorable, sparking a connection and setting the stage for the romantic tension to come. It's important to introduce the two protagonists early in the story to capture readers' interest and establish the foundation of their relationship. After all, with the romance between them being so overwhelmingly important, the story really begins at the meet-cute.

So, don't dillydally with backstory (you can fill that in later) but introduce the personalities of your two lovers-to-be quickly and let us see enough of them to know, at least in broad strokes, what they're like (and a hint that their personalities may conflict) and then bring them to their

first encounter straight-up. The meet-cute itself is a complete scene. It can take various forms, from accidental encounters (the clichéd example would be one bumps into the other in a crowded street, spilling the other's groceries, books, etc.) to planned meetings (one is interviewing the other for a job or, better, turns up with the other at the same interview as they are each competing for the same role), but it should always leave a lasting impression on both the characters and the readers. And the meet-cute is rarely, if ever, an overt “love at first sight” encounter. While there should certainly be attraction on both parts, there is often tension, too. In fact, even if the first meeting “goes well” on the surface, you must sow the seeds of a conflict that will split them apart later on. But don't worry if you're not sure how this works. We'll look at it next.

Create barriers and drive conflict

No love story is complete without obstacles and conflict that keeps the hero and heroine apart. Honestly, what kind of story would it be in which the protagonists met, fell in love, and lived happily ever after without first going through some kind of struggle, misunderstanding, and even suffering, to win their love for each other? These barriers can be emotional, physical, or external factors—and ideally, they'll be both—that create tension and heighten the stakes of the romance.

As you plan your novel, work out what challenges your characters will face and how they will work to overcome them. Whether it's family expectations, past traumas, or societal pressures, these barriers should test the strength of the characters' love and provide opportunities for growth and development. And not only that, a core conflict (usually based on a misunderstanding) should drive the characters apart somewhere around the midpoint of the novel. The rest is about how they respond and interact until they finally resolve the conflict, overcome the barrier, or recognize the misunderstanding for what it is and resolve to stay together.

Balance escapism with realism

A well-crafted plot is essential in any genre, and romance is no exception. To engage readers and keep them invested in the story, it's crucial to create a plot that is believable and realistic. While romance novels often involve elements of fantasy and escapism—really, that's what the readers want!—It's important to ground the story in a relatable and plausible world. If you don't, strangely, readers aren't able to enjoy the fantasy. Part of the pleasure of the romantic ideal is that it seems, even if only while reading the novel, possible.

Avoid plotlines that feel contrived or disconnected or like perfect fairytales, as this can pull readers out of the story. Romance readers want the illusion that such a story could, if only it could, but it could, actually happen to them. Taking the time to outline your novel while you work out how to interweave all these elements in your narrative will help make sure that your plot flows smoothly and enthralls readers from beginning to end.

7. Build emotional tension

Emotional tension is the heart and soul of any romance novel. It's the spark that ignites the chemistry between the hero and heroine or the two protagonists and keeps readers eagerly turning the pages. While physical attraction is important, true emotional tension goes beyond mere physicality—another reason this genre isn't the exclusive domain of Cis-gendered heterosexual writers and readers. It's about creating a connection between the characters that feels authentic, and emotionally convincing. Consider how your characters interact, the way they communicate, and the subtle moments of intimacy that build anticipation, cut up as they must be by moments of misunderstanding and confusion. By intentionally placing your characters in challenging romantic situations and allowing their emotions to unfold organically, you can create

a powerful and captivating love story that goes deeper than the obvious without breaking the rules of reader expectations.

The “will they, won’t they?” dynamic

A hallmark of the romance genre is the so-called “will they, won’t they?” dynamic, which keeps readers on the edge of their seats, wondering if the two protagonists will ever find their way to each other, if they’ll resolve conflict or misunderstanding that keeps them apart, and finally come together in love and—probably—marriage. This suspense is created by introducing external conflicts that challenge the characters’ relationship and create doubt about their future together. It could be a forbidden love, a secret from the past, or a rival for the hero or heroine’s affection. By introducing these obstacles, you can heighten the emotional stakes and keep readers invested in the romance’s outcome.

A happy ever after

One of the defining features of a romance novel—whether hetero, rainbow, straight, or even kinky—is the promise of a satisfying conclusion. And that means only one thing and done thing only: a happy ending. Whether it’s a “happily ever after” or a “happy for now” ending, readers of the romance genre expect a resolution that leaves them feeling emotionally fulfilled. Your characters should make a commitment to each other by the end of the book, solidifying their love and providing closure for the readers. Avoid leaving readers hanging or feeling disappointed by providing the emotional satisfaction they crave. Give them the love, hope, and happily ever after they desire.

Understand your readers

To write a successful romance novel, it's essential to understand the readers of the genre. According to an important study commissioned by the Romance Writers of America,

- 82% of readers are women
- 86% are heterosexual
- Most readers are under 34 years old
- **92% prefer to read in print**
- The most popular subgenres are suspense, erotic, and historical

However, the genre is also attracting a more diverse readership, including male readers (18% and growing) and individuals from various ethnic backgrounds and sexual orientations. Younger readers, in particular, are embracing the romance genre and exploring subgenres such as young adult, erotic, and paranormal romance. To connect with your target audience, it's important to stay informed about the developing preferences and expectations of romance readers. We've highlighted the fact that 92% of romance readers prefer to read printed books rather than eBooks. We print books! And so we can also confirm that romance is one genre we are most requested to print in fiction.

Write your romance, and then print it with us!

Writing a romance novel is an opportunity to create a world filled with love, passion, and unforgettable characters. By incorporating the essential elements of romance writing, from relatable characters to emotional tension and a satisfying conclusion, you can craft a love story that resonates with readers. Remember to embrace the magic of romance writing and let your imagination soar as you bring your characters' love story to life. With dedication, creativity, and

a deep understanding of the genre, you can write a romance novel that will captivate readers and leave them longing for more.

Writing a romance novel is a journey of passion and creativity. With these 10 essential elements in mind, you are well-equipped to embark on your own journey of crafting a love story that will touch the hearts of readers, explore the power of love, the depths of emotional connection, and create characters that will live on in the minds of readers long after they've turned the final page.